

# THE BETTER YOURSELF PROJECT

Goodbody Summer Academy 2025 A tangible skill you build all summer long

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## What Is The Better Yourself Project?

Each summer, you pick ONE real, tangible skill and work on it for 8 weeks. Not a worksheet. Not a test. Something you can SHOW PEOPLE — a photo portfolio, something you built, food you cooked, art you made. On Family Project Day at the end of summer, you present what you created and what you learned.

### Rules:

- Pick ONE project — don't switch halfway through
  - Document your progress (photos, journal, or both)
  - Hit 2 milestones (Week 3 and Week 6) to earn GBB
  - Present your project on Family Project Day (Week 8)
  - The goal is GROWTH, not perfection
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## ■ PHOTOGRAPHY

See the world through a different lens

Learn the basics of photography — composition, lighting, storytelling through images. Take 50+ photos over the summer and curate your 12 best into a printed portfolio or framed display.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                   |
|-----------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Camera basics: rule of thirds, lighting, focus. Take 20 practice shots daily. |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Submit 10 edited photos showing 3 different subjects             |
| Weeks 4-5 | Theme shoot: Tell a story in 5 photos. Portrait vs. landscape vs. action.     |
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Pick your 20 best, edit them, print or compile to digital book   |
| Weeks 7-8 | Final portfolio: Choose 12 photos. Write a caption for each. Present!         |

**Supplies needed:** Smartphone or camera, free editing app (Snapseed), printer or photo print service

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## ■ BUILDING / WOODWORKING

Make something with your hands that will last

Work with Dad to build something real using wood — a bat rack, birdhouse, small shelf, or tool box. Learn measuring, marking, cutting, sanding, and finishing. Handle real tools safely.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                 |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Safety rules, tool names, measuring practice. Design your project on paper. |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Materials purchased, all pieces measured and cut               |
| Weeks 4-5 | Assembly phase — join pieces, check for square, fix as you go               |

|           |                                                                           |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Structure complete and sanded smooth                         |
| Weeks 7-8 | Finish: paint, stain, or seal. Add your name. Present the finished piece! |

**Supplies needed:** Wood (ask Dad), sandpaper, wood glue, nails/screws, paint or stain, safety glasses

## ■ COOKING & BAKING

Feed your family something made from scratch

Learn 8 recipes from scratch — not from a box. Keep a recipe journal with notes, photos, and ratings. The final milestone is hosting a complete family dinner where you cook everything.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                           |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Kitchen safety, knife basics, measuring. Cook recipes 1 & 2 with supervision.         |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Cook 3 complete recipes independently. Journal each one.                 |
| Weeks 4-5 | Try harder recipes. Bake something with multiple steps (bread, cookies from scratch). |
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Cook a full meal (protein + side + dessert) for the family               |
| Weeks 7-8 | Plan and execute Family Dinner: 3-course meal, set the table, serve it yourself       |

**Supplies needed:** Recipe journal/notebook, measuring cups, basic kitchen tools, groceries per recipe

## ■ VISUAL ART

Create a series that tells YOUR story

Learn 3 core art techniques: shading, color mixing, and perspective. Then create a 6-piece art series around a personal theme — baseball/softball, family, San Diego, summer, or anything meaningful to you.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                           |
|-----------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Technique 1: Shading (pencil value scale, 3D shapes). Fill a sketchbook page daily.   |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Complete 3 technique studies (shading, color, perspective)               |
| Weeks 4-5 | Plan your series: choose theme, sketch thumbnails for all 6 pieces. Start pieces 1-3. |
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Pieces 1-3 complete and mounted/matted                                   |
| Weeks 7-8 | Complete pieces 4-6. Write an artist statement. Present with display!                 |

**Supplies needed:** Sketchbook, pencils (HB, 2B, 4B), watercolors or colored pencils, white art paper, matting

## ■ SEWING & CRAFTING

Make something wearable or useful by hand

Learn hand stitching and basic machine sewing (if available). Start with simple projects and work up to making a pillow, a small bag, or a clothing item by the end of summer.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                             |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Thread a needle, basic stitches (running, backstitch, whip). Sew a pouch by hand.       |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Hand-sew a complete small item (pouch, simple case)                        |
| Weeks 4-5 | Machine sewing basics (if available): straight lines, curves, seams.                    |
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Complete a pillow or tote bag from start to finish                         |
| Weeks 7-8 | Final project: choose your best challenge (clothing item, quilt square, etc.). Present! |

**Supplies needed:** Thread, needles, fabric scraps, scissors, sewing machine (optional), pins

## ■ GROWING A GARDEN

Grow it, tend it, eat it

Plant 3 types of vegetables or herbs from seed or starter. Learn about soil, watering, sunlight, and plant life cycles. Track growth weekly. At the end, harvest and cook something with what you grew.

| TIMELINE  | WHAT YOU DO                                                                             |
|-----------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weeks 1-2 | Research plants, set up beds or containers, plant seeds/starters.                       |
| Week 3 ✓  | Milestone 1: Photo documentation of all 3 plants + first growth journal entry per plant |
| Weeks 4-5 | Maintenance: water schedule, thinning, pest check. Research what's happening.           |
| Week 6 ✓  | Milestone 2: Growth comparison photos (Week 1 vs. Week 6). First harvest if ready.      |
| Weeks 7-8 | Full harvest. Cook one dish using what you grew. Present garden + cooked dish!          |

**Supplies needed:** Pots or garden bed, soil, seeds or starters, watering can, garden journal, trowel

## TRACKING YOUR PROJECT

|                           | MILES | SABRINA |
|---------------------------|-------|---------|
| Chosen Project            |       |         |
| Goal by end of summer     |       |         |
| Week 3 Milestone          |       |         |
| Week 6 Milestone          |       |         |
| Family Project Day Reveal |       |         |
| GBB Earned (total)        |       |         |